
Pine Lake

Waukesha County, Wisconsin — 711 acres, 85 ft, very clear

Every sheet in the Lake Country guide, bound in one document: the lake and its depth map, a page for each species, a page for each rig, and the reference sheets. Each page is also published on its own, and the two are the same document — this is those sheets bound, not a rewriting of them.

Revised 2026-07-25. Regulations quoted anywhere in this document are the 2026–27 rules and they change every year. Only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.

What is in here

Part	Sheets
I. The lake	Pine Lake — overview, depth map with numbered spots, and the season-by-season table of what holds where
II. Species	Largemouth bass, smallmouth bass, walleye, northern pike, muskellunge, bluegill, pumpkinseed, black crappie, yellow perch, rock bass, cisco
III. Rigs	Slip bobber, lindy, Carolina, Texas, wacky, drop shot, jig-and-minnow, three-way, split shot, quick-strike, tip-up
IV. Reference	Reading water, lures and baits, the seasonal calendar, knots, handling and release, a first trip

How to use it

The numbered spots on the depth map are the guide’s spine. Every species sheet and most rig sheets refer back to them, so Pine 4” or North 5” always means the same piece of water. Read the lake sheet first; after that the guide is meant to be flipped through rather than read.

I The Lake

The water itself: what it is made of, how deep it goes, where the structure is, and which of the nine (or seven) marked spots is worth your time in which month.

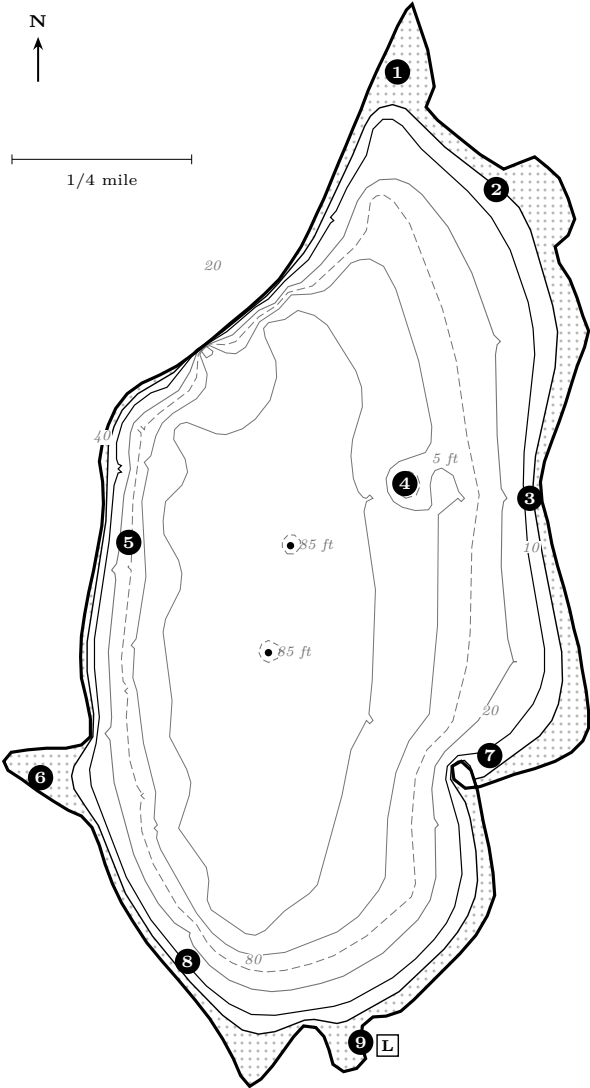
Pine Lake

Town of Merton & Village of Chenequa

Waukesha County, Wisconsin — 711 acres, 85 ft maximum depth

Pine Lake is deep, cold and startlingly clear, and almost everything that makes it hard to fish follows from those three facts. Ninety per cent of the bottom is gravel. The water clears far enough that weeds grow past 15 ft, that fish see your line, and that the best bites come at the edges of the day. It stratifies hard by early summer into a warm upper layer and a cold, oxygenated basin below, and it holds cisco — an open-water forage fish — which means the biggest predators in this lake spend much of the summer suspended over 60 ft of water rather than sitting on the weed edge where you would like them to be.

Surface	711 acres (698 acres on the 1955 survey); 6.7 miles of shoreline
Depth	85 ft maximum, 39 ft mean — one of the deepest lakes in the county
Bottom	Gravel 90%, muck 5%, sand 5%. Hard bottom nearly everywhere
Clarity	Very clear. Expect weed growth to 15–20 ft and spooky fish in calm sun
Fish	Largemouth and smallmouth bass (common), panfish, northern pike, walleye (stocked as large fingerlings in alternate years), cisco
Access	One public launch, Village of Chenequa. 6 a.m.–10 p.m., except the general fishing opener when it opens 4 a.m.–midnight. Launch fees apply (roughly \$8–\$15 by boat length); verify current hours and fees



Depth in feet. Schematic — not for navigation. Redrawn from the Wisconsin Conservation Department lake survey of 6 June 1955 (WBIC 779200), published by the Wisconsin DNR as a public document. Contours are reconstructed from that survey's soundings and are generalized.

under 5 ft shoreline 5 & 10 ft 20 ft 30 ft 40 & 60 ft 80 ft ④ spot L public launch

The nine spots, by season

Depths below are where the fish are, not where the spot is. Everything on this lake runs deeper than you expect because the water is so clear.

#	Spot	When & what	How
1	North arm shallows	Apr–early Jun: bluegill, pumpkinseed, largemouth, early pike. Nov–Mar: panfish under ice.	First water in the lake to warm. Fish 3–8 ft over emerging weed. Slip bobber and a small leech or half a crawler; a weightless wacky-rigged worm for bass.
2	North-east shoreline break	May–Jun smallmouth; Sep–Nov walleye and pike.	A scalloped shore with points and pockets and a fast drop. Work the points with a jig-and-minnow along the 12–20 ft line; cast tubes to the rock in spring.
3	East wall	Jul–Sep smallmouth, walleye, suspended fish.	The steepest drop in the lake — 20 ft is a short cast from shore. Drop-shot or a slow lindy rig down the 25–40 ft face. Best at first and last light.
4	Mid-lake bar	Jun–Oct , the whole cast: smallmouth, walleye, crappie, big pike.	A hard 5 ft crest surrounded by 60 ft. The single best piece of structure here. Start on top at dawn, then follow the fish down the sides to 18–30 ft as the sun climbs. Jig-and-minnow, drop-shot, or a deep crankbait on the edge.
5	West shelf	May–Sep largemouth and bluegill; Oct pike.	The gentlest slope in the lake, with the deepest weed growth. Fish the outside weed edge at 12–18 ft. Texas-rigged plastic through the weeds, slip bobber on the edge.
6	West bay	Late May–Jun bluegill and pumpkinseed on beds; largemouth all summer. Jan–Feb panfish.	Shallow, protected and weedy — the classic spawning bay. Small hook, small bait, light line, and stay back from the beds. Prime water to put a child on fish.
7	South-east bay	Apr–May crappie and bluegill; Jun–Aug largemouth.	A small round pocket that warms early and holds spring fish before the main lake turns on. Slip bobber over 6–12 ft.
8	South-west taper	Sep–Nov walleye and pike; Jun–Aug smallmouth deep.	Deep water swings close to the bank here. Troll or drift the 20–35 ft break with a lindy rig and a big minnow in fall.
9	Outlet bay	Apr–May and Oct–Nov pike; panfish in summer.	Shallow, weedy, with some current. Pike stage here early and again in fall. Big sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, or a spinnerbait over the weed tops.

Reading the year

Ice-out–April	Everything is shallow and everything is in the bays. Spots 1, 6, 7, 9. Water under 50 °F: slow down, use bait.
May–June	Spawn moves through in order — pike first, then walleye, then bass, then panfish last on the beds. Fish stay shallow. Bass season opens the first Saturday in May; check the current dates.
July–August	The lake stratifies. Panfish and largemouth hold the deep weed edge (spots 5, 6); smallmouth, walleye and big pike go to the bar and the east wall (3, 4) or suspend over the basin chasing cisco.
September–October	Turnover scatters fish for a week or two, then the best fishing of the year begins. Big fish move up onto structure and eat hard. Spots 2, 4, 8.
November–ice	Deep and slow. The bar and the east wall hold fish into December.
Ice season	Panfish in the bays (1, 6); pike on tip-ups over the weed edges. <i>Walleye, bass and pike close 7 March; panfish stay open.</i>

CHECK THE REGULATIONS BEFORE EVERY TRIP

The 2026–27 rules for this water are: largemouth and smallmouth bass 14in minimum, 5 per day, 2 May–7 March, catch-and-release the rest of the year; walleye 18in minimum, 3 per day; northern pike 26in minimum, 2 per day; muskellunge 40in minimum, 1 per day, open water only through 31 December; panfish 25 per day; cisco and whitefish 10 per day. **These change.** The Wisconsin DNR publishes the current rules for this exact water body, and only that publication is authoritative.

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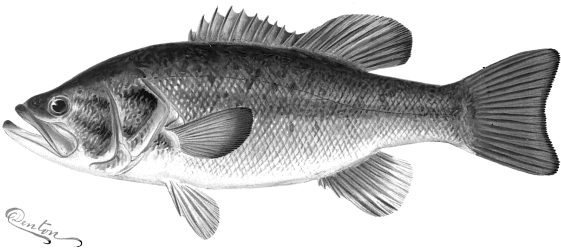
II Species

One page each. How to tell it apart from the fish it gets confused with, where it lives in this lake, when it spawns, and how to catch it. The plates are public-domain chromolithographs by S. F. Denton, published in the New York fisheries reports around 1896–1902.

Largemouth Bass

The weed-edge ambusher — Pine Lake & North Lake

Micropterus salmoides



The Large-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

The jaw. On a largemouth the upper jaw reaches *past* the back of the eye; on a smallmouth it stops under the eye. Largemouth are green with one ragged dark stripe down the side, and the dorsal fin is pinched almost in two.

Size here

12–16 in is a normal fish, 18 in is a good one, 20 in is a trophy for these lakes. State record 11 lb 3 oz.

Spawn

Beds in 1–4 ft of sand or gravel in protected bays when the water holds 60–65 °F — late May into June. The male fans the bed and guards the fry for weeks afterward.

Eats

Anything it can fit: bluegill, perch, crayfish, frogs, young of its own kind.

Season

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■

Time of day

Dawn	Mid	Dusk	Night
■	■	■	■

Where

- Pine

Spots **5** (west shelf), **6** (west bay), **7** (south-east bay). The water is so clear that the weed line runs to 15–20 ft, and so does the bass. Do not stop fishing at 8 ft because that is where you would stop on a normal lake.
- North

Spots **1**, **4**, **5**, **7**. Stained water pulls them shallow — 4–10 ft is the band.
- Structure

Weed edges, isolated weed clumps, fallen wood, docks, and any hard-to-soft bottom transition. A largemouth wants something to hide behind and open water to charge into.

How

- Search

Spinnerbait or a squarebill crankbait along the weed edge to find active fish fast, then slow down and pick the area apart.
- In the weeds

Texas-rigged plastic worm or creature bait, *see the **Texas rig** sheet*. Weedless, sinks slowly, comes through everything.
- Pressured or clear

Weightless wacky-rigged worm, *see the **wacky rig** sheet*. On Pine Lake in bright sun this out-fishes everything else.
- Deep

A jig-and-craw or a Carolina rig on the outside weed edge, *see the **Carolina rig** sheet*.
- First and last light

A walking topwater or a popper over the weed tops. The best half hour of the day.
- For a beginner

A nightcrawler under a slip bobber set to hang just above the weeds. It is not fancy and it works.

The one thing to remember

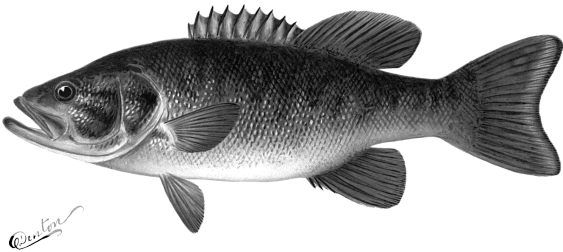
Largemouth relate to *cover*, not depth. Find the edge — of the weeds, of the shade, of the drop — and fish it. In the middle of a featureless flat there is no bass.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 14 in minimum, 5 per day, open 2 May–7 March. Catch-and-release open all year. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Smallmouth Bass

Micropterus dolomieu

Rock, gravel and hard bottom — Pine Lake & North Lake



The Small-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Size here

Spawn

Eats

Season

Time of day

Bronze rather than green, with dark *vertical* bars instead of one horizontal stripe, and a red or orange eye. The upper jaw stops under the eye. The dorsal fin is one continuous fin, not pinched.

12–17 in typical; 18 in and up is a strong fish. State record 9 lb 1 oz. Pound for pound the hardest-fighting fish in either lake.

Gravel and rubble in 3–10 ft at 60–65 °F, a little later and deeper than largemouth. Pine Lake’s 90% gravel bottom is close to ideal smallmouth habitat.

Crayfish above all, then minnows, perch fry and insect larvae. Match the crayfish and you are most of the way there.

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
■		■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■
■		■		■		■		■		■	
■		■		■		■		■		■	
Dawn		Mid		Dusk		Night					

Where

- Pine

This is a smallmouth lake. Spots **2** (north-east breaks), **3** (east wall), **4** (the mid-lake bar) and **8**. The bar is the best smallmouth spot in the county on a good October morning.
- North

Spots **3** and **4**. The south-end shoal complex is the equivalent of Pine’s bar.
- Structure

Hard bottom with a fast change in depth. Rock points, gravel bars, rip-rap, boulder fields. If your jig comes back scuffed, you are in the right place.
- Season

Shallow and aggressive in May–June, deep and moody in July–August, then shallow and violent again in late September and October.

How

- Best all-round

A tube jig dragged and hopped on the bottom. It looks exactly like a fleeing crayfish and nothing else is needed most days.
- Deep and finicky

Drop-shot with a small minnow-shaped plastic, *see the **drop-shot** sheet*. This is how you fish Pine Lake’s east wall in August.
- Cold water

A suspending jerkbait, worked with long pauses. In 45–55 °F water the pause is the whole presentation.
- Live bait

A live crayfish or a large leech on a plain hook with one split shot, *see the **split shot** sheet*. Deadly and simple.
- Line

Fluorocarbon on Pine Lake. The water is clear enough that it matters.

The one thing to remember

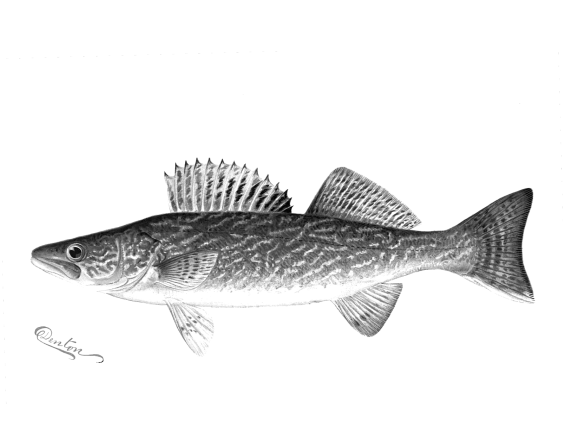
Smallmouth live where the bottom is hard. Largemouth live where the cover is soft. On the same lake, on the same day, that one distinction sorts almost every spot.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 14 in minimum, 5 per day, open 2 May–7 March. Catch-and-release open all year. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Walleye

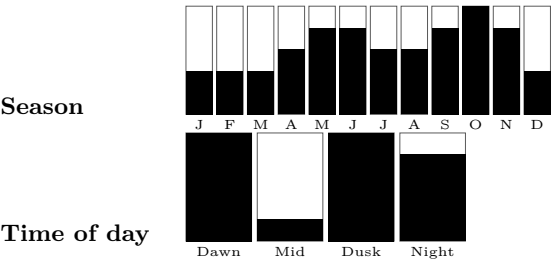
The low-light specialist — Pine Lake & North Lake

Sander vitreus



The Pike Perch or Wall-Eyed Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

- Tell it apart** A **white tip on the lower lobe of the tail** and a dark blotch at the rear base of the spiny dorsal fin. The eye is large and glassy — a reflective layer behind the retina lets it see in water too dark for its prey. Long canine teeth.
- Not a sauger** Sauger have rows of black spots on the spiny dorsal, dark saddles, and no white tail tip. Not expected here, but worth knowing.
- Size here** 15–22 in. The 18 in minimum means most fish you catch go back. State record 18 lb.
- Spawn** Earliest of the gamefish after pike: 42–50 °F, late March into April, over rock and gravel shorelines and in inflows. Pine Lake is stocked with large fingerlings in alternate years.



Where

- Pine** Spots **3** (east wall), **4** (the bar) and **8**. In high summer they may suspend over the basin following cisco — do not assume they are on the bottom.
- North** Spots **3**, **4** (south-end shoals) and **5** (the neck). Stained water means they will be shallower than on Pine.
- Depth** The 18–30 ft break most of the year. Shallower at dawn, dusk and after dark; deeper in bright calm.
- Weather** Grey and windy is a walleye day. Wind on a point breaks up the light and pushes bait against structure — fish the windy side.

How

- Classic** Lindy rig with a leech, half a crawler, or a small minnow, dragged slowly along the contour, *see the lindy rig sheet*. Slow means slower than you think.
- Cold water** Jig-and-minnow, *see the jig-and-minnow sheet*, worked with tiny lifts. Most bites feel like weight, not a strike.
- Covering water** Troll a deep crankbait along the break. Motor trolling is allowed here, up to three hooks, baits or lures per angler.
- Steep faces** A three-way rig holds a precise depth where a lindy rig will not, *see the three-way rig sheet*.
- Timing** The last forty minutes of light beat the rest of the day. Be on the spot before the sun goes.

The one thing to remember

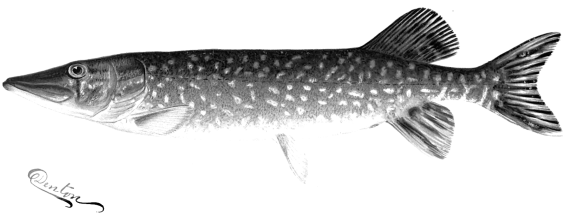
Walleye are not hard to catch; they are hard to be present for. Their eyes give them an advantage in dim light, so they feed when you would rather be at the landing. Fish the edges of the day.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 18 in minimum, 3 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Northern Pike

Esox lucius

First to spawn, last to quit — Pine Lake & North Lake



The Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	Light bean-shaped spots on a dark green body — light-on-dark. The cheek is fully scaled and the lower half of the gill cover is bare. Five sensory pores along each side of the lower jaw.																								
Not a musky	A musky is the photographic negative: <i>dark</i> marks on a <i>light</i> body, the lower half of both the cheek and gill cover bare, and six to nine pores per side. At a 40 in minimum on musky and 26 in on pike, this matters.																								
Size here	20–30 in is the working range; 36 in and up is a real fish. State record 38 lb.																								
Spawn	The first gamefish to go, immediately after ice-out at 40–45 °F, in flooded marsh grass and shallow vegetation — often before the ice is fully gone from the main lake.																								
Season	<table><tr><td>J</td><td>F</td><td>M</td><td>A</td><td>M</td><td>J</td><td>J</td><td>A</td><td>S</td><td>O</td><td>N</td><td>D</td></tr><tr><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td></tr></table>	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■
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Time of day	<table><tr><td>Dawn</td><td>Mid</td><td>Dusk</td><td>Night</td></tr><tr><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td><td>■</td></tr></table>	Dawn	Mid	Dusk	Night	■	■	■	■																
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Where

Pine	Spots 1 and 9 in spring and fall, 5 along the deep weed edge in summer. In a lake this cold and clear, the largest pike go deep and cool in July and August — 25–40 ft on the edge of the basin, not in the shallows.
North	Spots 2 (outlet), 5 (the neck) and 6 (river inlet). Current and weed. This lake fishes more like a classic pike water than Pine does.
Cover	Weed edges, points, and any narrows. Pike are ambush hunters that want a wall at their back and open water in front.

How

Cover water	A large spinnerbait or a spoon over and along the weed tops. Fast, snag-resistant, and it finds the aggressive fish.
Big fish	A large sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, <i>see the quick-strike rig sheet</i> . This is how most of the biggest pike in these lakes are taken.
Ice	Tip-ups with a live shiner set just off the bottom along the weed edge, <i>see the tip-up sheet</i> .
Leader	Always. A wire or heavy fluorocarbon leader. Pike teeth cut straight line, and losing a fish with a hook in it is a bad outcome for the fish, not just for you.

HANDLING A PIKE

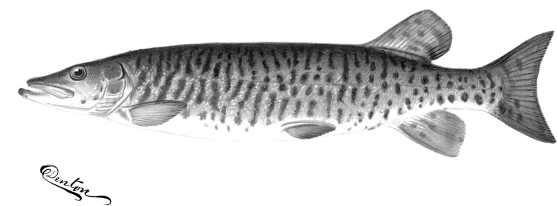
The teeth are backward-facing and will cut you to the bone. Long pliers and jaw spreaders, always; fingers never go in the mouth or under the gill plate. Support a big fish horizontally with a wet hand under the belly. Above roughly 70 °F a released pike is fragile — unhook it in the net, in the water, and let it go.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 26 in minimum, 2 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Muskellunge

Esox masquinongy

An incidental fish here — but know it on sight



The Mascalonge — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Pattern	Dark bars or spots on a <i>light</i> body — the exact reverse of a northern pike.
Cheek	Lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless.
Jaw pores	Six to nine per side. A pike has five or fewer.
Tail	Lobes come to sharper points than a pike's.
Minimum	40 in, 1 per day, open water only.

Why this sheet exists
Muskellunge are not among the species the DNR lists as common in Pine Lake or North Lake. They are nonetheless regulated on both waters, at a 40 in minimum and one fish per day. If you hook a large esocid here it is almost certainly a northern pike — but you must be able to prove that to yourself before you decide what to do with it, because the two fish carry different minimum lengths and different seasons.

Musky or pike? Three checks, in order

1. Pattern	Musky: dark bars or spots on a light background. Pike: light bean-shaped spots on a dark background. The two are photographic negatives of one another.
2. Cheek & gill cover	Look at the side of the head. Musky: the lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless. Pike: the whole cheek is scaled; only the lower gill cover is bare.
3. Jaw pores	Turn the head and count the pores along one side of the underside of the lower jaw. Musky: six to nine. Pike: five or fewer. This is the check that settles an argument.
Tail	A musky's tail lobes come to sharper points; a pike's are more rounded. Useful as confirmation, not as the deciding test.
Tiger musky	A pike-musky hybrid, with bold wavy bars and rounded tail lobes. It falls under the musky regulations.

If you do hook one

Decide fast	Measure it in the net, in the water. Under 40 in it goes back, full stop.
Gear	A big musky cannot be landed responsibly on panfish tackle. A large net, long pliers, jaw spreaders and bolt cutters for a buried hook are the minimum.
Release	Keep it horizontal and in the water. A musky is a long, heavy fish and its own weight in air injures it. Revive it facing into the current or move it gently forward until it swims off under its own power.
Season	Open water only, 2 May–31 December — unlike pike, there is no ice season for musky.

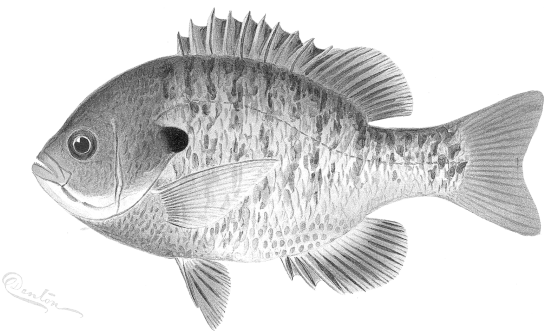
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 40 in minimum, 1 per day, open water only, 2 May–31 December. A misidentified fish is still a violation. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Muskellunge. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus

The best fish in the lake to learn on



Blue Gill Sun Fish — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

A solid black ear flap with no coloured margin, a dark smudge at the rear base of the soft dorsal fin, a small mouth, and long pointed pectoral fins. Compare with the pumpkinseed, which has an orange-red spot on the flap and wavy blue lines on the cheek.

Size here

6–8 in is a good fish; a 9 in bluegill is a genuine trophy and worth releasing so it keeps breeding.

Spawn

67–70 °F, late May into June, in dense colonies of saucer-shaped beds on sand or gravel in 1–4 ft. You can see the beds from the boat and often smell them.

Eats

Insect larvae, small crustaceans, snails. A small mouth means small baits.

Season

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■

Time of day

Dawn	Mid	Dusk	Night
■	■	■	■

Where

- Pine**

Spots **6** (west bay) and **1** on the beds in June, then out to the deep weed edge at **5** — 12–18 ft — for the rest of the summer. Bluegill on Pine go deeper than most people expect.
- North**

Spots **1** and **7**, and the weed flats generally. 4–10 ft.
- Winter**

Basin edges and remaining green weed at 10–20 ft. Bays **6** on Pine, **1** on North.

How

- The rig**

A slip bobber, a small split shot, and a size 8 or 10 hook, *see the slip bobber sheet*. Set the depth so the bait rides just above the weed tops.
- Bait**

A piece of nightcrawler — not a whole one — a waxworm, a leaf worm, or a small leech. Bluegill have small mouths and will strip a big bait without ever getting hooked.
- Artificial**

A 1/32 oz jig with a small plastic tail, or a small foam spider on a fly rod during the June bed period.
- Line**

4lb. Anything heavier telegraphs badly on a small float and costs you bites.
- With a child**

This is the fish. Anchor over a bed in June, use a fixed bobber a foot or two deep, and expect constant action. Barbless or pinched barbs make unhooking fast and safe.

Fish the beds gently

Bedding bluegill are easy to catch and easy to strip out of a bay. Take a meal, not a cooler. The biggest males guard the beds, and removing them all is how a lake ends up full of stunted four-inch fish.

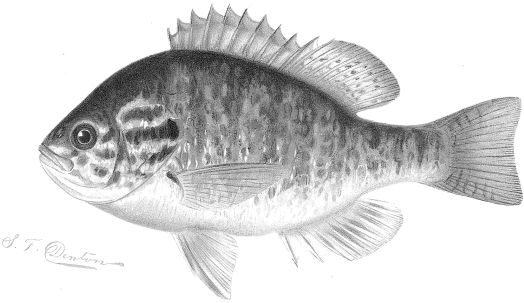
Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Bluegill. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Pumpkinseed

The other sunfish on the bed

Lepomis gibbosus



Sunfish (*Eupomotis gibbosus*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	An orange-red spot on the trailing edge of the black ear flap, and wavy pale-blue lines radiating back across the cheek and gill cover. The fins are speckled. There is <i>no</i> dark blotch at the back of the soft dorsal — that blotch belongs to the bluegill.
Shape	Rounder and deeper-bodied than a bluegill, with a slightly larger mouth and shorter, more rounded pectoral fins.
Size here	5–7 in. Rarely as large as a good bluegill, and usually a smaller share of the catch.
Spawn	Same window as bluegill, 65–70 °F, often on the same colonial beds — and the two species hybridize, which is why you will occasionally land something that fits neither description.
Eats	Snails above all — it has crushing teeth in its throat for them — plus insect larvae and small crustaceans.
Season	

Where and how

Habitat	Shallower and weedier than bluegill, and more tied to cover. Pine spots 6 and 1 ; North spots 1 and 7 .
Depth	1–8 ft, in and against vegetation. If you are catching bluegill on the deep weed edge and pumpkinseed on the inside edge, that is normal.
Rig	Identical to bluegill — slip bobber, split shot, size 8 or 10 hook, small piece of worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.

Worth knowing on the bed

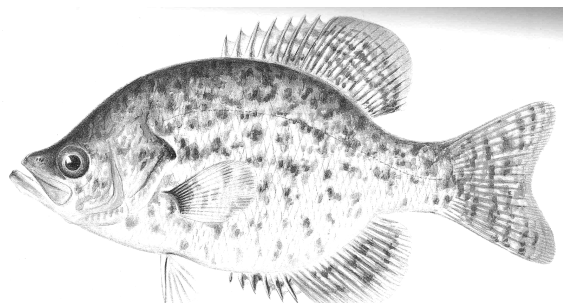
When you find a June sunfish colony you will usually be catching both species plus the occasional hybrid. Sorting them on the spot is a good five-minute lesson for a child: flip the gill cover into the light and look for the orange dot.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Pumpkinseed. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Black Crappie

A roaming, suspending, low-light panfish

Pomoxis nigromaculatus



Calico Bass; Strawberry Bass (*Pomoxis sparoides*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

The paper mouth

Size here

Spawn

Eats

Season

Time of day

Count the dorsal spines: seven or eight on a black crappie, five or six on a white crappie. The speckling is scattered and irregular, not organised into vertical bars. The body is deep, thin and silvery.

The membrane around the jaw tears easily. Do not set hard and do not lift a crappie by the line — this is the fish people lose at the side of the boat.

8–11 in. A 12 in crappie is a very good fish.

58–64 °F, May, in 3–8 ft near brush, wood or the inside weed edge. Slightly earlier and slightly deeper than bluegill.

Small minnows and zooplankton. More fish-eating than the sunfish, which is why a minnow beats a worm.

Month	Dawn	Mid	Dusk	Night
J	Low	Low	Low	Low
F	Low	Low	Low	Low
M	Low	Low	Low	Low
A	Low	Low	Low	Low
M	Low	Low	Low	Low
J	Low	Low	High	High
J	Low	Low	High	High
A	Low	Low	Low	Low
S	Low	Low	Low	Low
O	Low	Low	Low	Low
N	Low	Low	Low	Low
D	Low	Low	Low	Low

Where

- Pine**

North

The key habit

Spot **7** (south-east bay) and **6** in spring; the edges of the mid-lake bar **4** in summer, where they suspend off the drop.

Spots **1** and **4**, and anywhere with standing wood.

Crappie **suspend**. They roam in schools at a chosen depth over deep water, ignoring the bottom entirely. Finding the depth matters far more than finding the spot.

How

- Find the depth**

Best bait

Artificial

Hookset

When

Cast a small jig, count it down — five, ten, fifteen — and retrieve. When you get bit, remember the count and repeat it exactly.

A small live minnow under a slip bobber, *see the **slip bobber sheet***, set precisely at the depth you found. Crappie feed *upward*; set the bait slightly above them, never below.

1/16 or 1/32 oz jig with a soft plastic tail, in white or chartreuse. Barely move it.

A steady sweep, not a snap. Paper mouth.

Dusk is the crappie hour. They also feed well in the first hour of an overcast morning and through the ice in January.

The one thing to remember

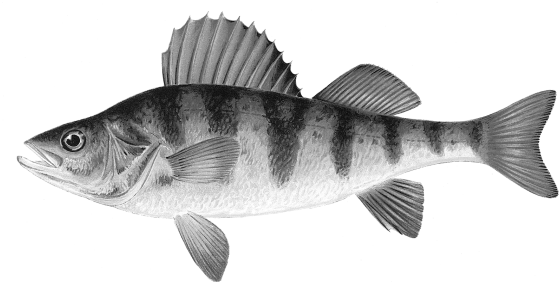
If you are catching nothing, change your *depth* before you change your bait. A school two feet below your jig will not come up for it, and a school two feet above it never sees it.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Yellow Perch

Perca flavescens

A daylight schooling fish — and the walleye’s opposite



Yellow or Barred Perch — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

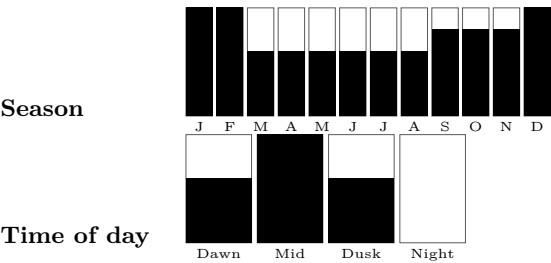
Tell it apart Six to eight dark **vertical bars** over a yellow-green body, with orange lower fins. Two separate dorsal fins, the first spiny. Unmistakable.

Size here 6–10 in. A 10 in perch is a fine fish and among the best eating in either lake.

Spawn 45–52 °F, April, and unlike any other fish here the female lays a long accordion-folded ribbon of eggs draped over weeds and brush. You will see them in the shallows.

Eats Insect larvae, small crustaceans, minnows and fish eggs. Perch are also the primary food of walleye and pike — which is exactly why they school.

Habit **A daytime feeder.** Perch shut down at night, when walleye switch on. They travel in tight schools on the bottom.



Where

Pine The deep weed edge at spot **5**, the flats around the base of the bar **4**, and the 15–30 ft bottom generally.

North Spots **1**, **3** and **4**. Shallower than on Pine because of the stain.

Bottom Perch stay on or near the bottom on clean sand, gravel or the base of weeds. If you are more than a foot off the bottom you are fishing over them.

Winter One of the best ice fish in either lake, on the same 15–30 ft flats.

How

Best rig A small jig tipped with a minnow head, a piece of crawler or a waxworm, fished right on the bottom. Or a drop-shot with a very short tag, *see the **drop-shot** sheet*.

Move to find them Perch schools are tight. If you catch two and then nothing, the school moved — move with it rather than waiting.

Stay on them When you find a school, drop straight back down immediately. A hooked fish drags the school with it and a slow re-bait costs you the whole group.

Eating Excellent — firm, white, mild. This is the fish worth keeping a limit of.

The lesson to teach

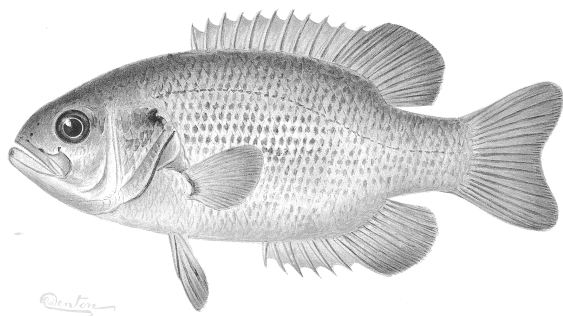
Perch and walleye eat the same food in the same water but never at the same hour: one has eyes built for daylight, the other for dusk. That single fact explains most of the daily rhythm of both lakes.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

Rock Bass

Red-eyed, abundant, and always willing

Ambloplites rupestris



Rock Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	A bright red eye , a large mouth for a panfish, and rows of dark spots along the scale lines giving a dotted-stripe look. The clinching check: six spines in the anal fin . Bluegill, pumpkinseed and the other sunfish have three.
Colour	It can flush from pale olive to near-black in seconds, so colour alone will mislead you. Use the eye and the anal spines.
Size here	6–9 in. Abundant on Pine Lake, whose gravel bottom is exactly what they want.
Spawn	Late May into June at 60–70 °F, in shallow nests scooped on gravel near rock, often close to smallmouth beds.
Eats	Crayfish, insect larvae and small fish. Aggressive well out of proportion to its size.
Season	

Where and how

Habitat	Rock, gravel, rip-rap and boulder. Pine spots 2, 3, 4 and 8 ; North spots 3 and 4 . Wherever you fish for smallmouth you will find rock bass first.
Depth	2–20 ft, tight to the bottom and tight to cover.
Rig	They will take anything. A split-shot rig with a worm, a small jig, a tube — it hardly matters. <i>see the split shot sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.
Eating	Perfectly good — white and mild, if a little softer than perch. Under-appreciated.

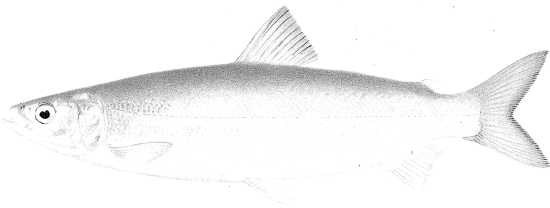
Use them
Rock bass are the fish that saves a slow morning with a child, and they are the fish that tells you your smallmouth spot has the right bottom. Neither is a small thing. If you are catching rock bass on a new piece of structure, keep working it.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Rock Bass. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Cisco

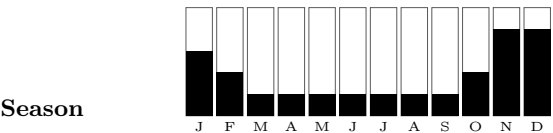
Coregonus artedii — also called lake herring

The deep-water forage fish that explains Pine Lake



Cisco from Hemlock Lake (*Argyrosomus artedii*) — plate from the Freshwater and Marine Image Bank, University of Washington. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	Slim, bright silver, deeply forked tail, small toothless mouth, and a small fleshy adipose fin between the dorsal and the tail — the mark of a salmonid. Nothing else in these lakes has one.
Size here	8–14 in.
Why it matters	Cisco need cold water that still holds oxygen through the summer. Very few lakes in south-eastern Wisconsin can supply that. Their presence is a direct statement about the quality and depth of Pine Lake’s basin.
Spawn	Very late — November into December, over shallow gravel, often as the lake is cooling toward ice.
Eats	Zooplankton, out in open water. It is a pelagic fish that almost never touches bottom or structure.



What it means for your fishing

Suspended predators	Through July and August, cisco hold in the cold layer below the thermocline over Pine Lake’s 60–85 ft basin, and the biggest walleye, pike and smallmouth follow them out there. This is why the structure bite can die in high summer while the lake is still full of large fish — they are not on the structure at all.
What to do about it	Watch your electronics over open water between spots 3 and 4 . Marks at 30–45 ft over 70 ft of water in August are usually cisco, and often something larger nearby.
Bait size	Where predators are eating a 10 in silver fish, a 3 in minnow is a poor imitation. Size up in late summer.
Catching them	Mostly incidental. They will take a small jig or spoon fished deep, and they are a known ice-fishing target on lakes that hold them. 10 per day; open all year.
Eating	Excellent, oily and fine-textured. Traditionally smoked.

A lesson in the lake

A lake is a stack of layers, not a bowl. In summer Pine Lake has warm water on top, a sharp temperature step in the middle, and cold water below — and different fish live in each. Cisco are the clearest evidence that the bottom layer is alive. Explaining that to a child on the water is worth more than a limit of bluegill.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Cisco. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

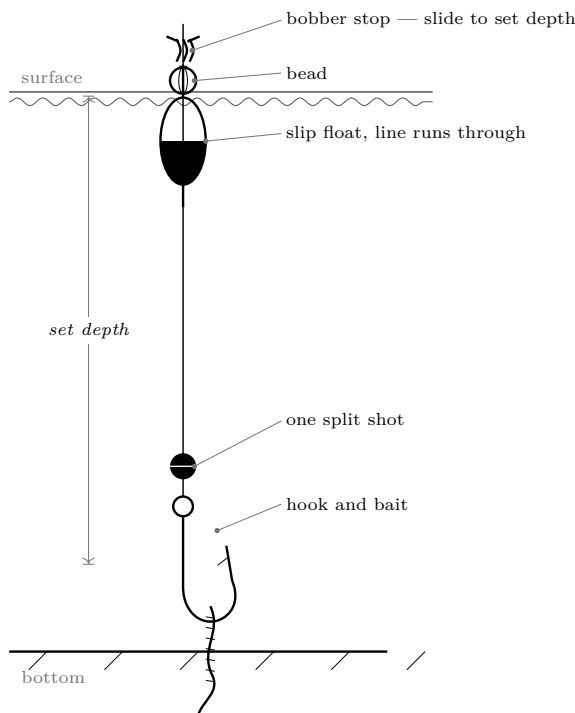
III Rigs

One page each: a drawing of the assembled rig, what every component is for, how to build it, and how to fish it. Roughly in order of how often you will tie them.

Slip Bobber

Hold a live bait at an exact depth, in any depth of water

The first rig to learn and the last one to give up



What it does	The float slides freely on the line until it hits the stop knot. You can fish 20 ft down and still reel the float to the rod tip to cast.
Why it matters	A fixed bobber can only fish as deep as your rod is long. A slip float has no such limit, which is the whole reason it exists.
Components	Bobber stop (thread or rubber), small bead, slip float, one or two split shot, hook.
Hook	Size 8–10 for panfish, 4–6 for crappie on a minnow, 1/0 for bass or walleye on a leech.
Line	4 lb for panfish; 6–8 lb for bass and walleye.
Catches	Bluegill, pumpkinseed, crappie, perch, largemouth, walleye, pike.

Build it

1. Thread the **bobber stop** onto the main line and slide it up. Tighten it enough to hold but loose enough to slide when you pull — this is what you will adjust all day.
2. Thread the **bead**. Its only job is to stop the small stop knot from pulling through the float's hole.
3. Thread the **float**, top end first.
4. Pinch on **split shot** 8–12 in above where the hook will be. Enough weight that the float sits upright with only its tip showing — an over-floated bobber cannot signal a bite.
5. Tie on the **hook** with an improved clinch knot, *see the **knots** sheet*.

Fish it

Set the depth	Bait should ride just above whatever the fish are holding on — the weed tops, the bottom, the school. Fish look up far more readily than down. Start a foot above and work down.
Read it	A bluegill takes the float sideways and down in small taps. A crappie lifts it and lays it flat — that is a fish swimming up with the bait, and it is a bite. Walleye pull it under slowly and steadily.
Set the hook	Reel the slack, then sweep. Do not snap a rod at a crappie, <i>see the Black Crappie sheet</i> .
Adjust	A float that lies flat and stays flat is too deep — the bait is on the bottom. Slide the stop down.

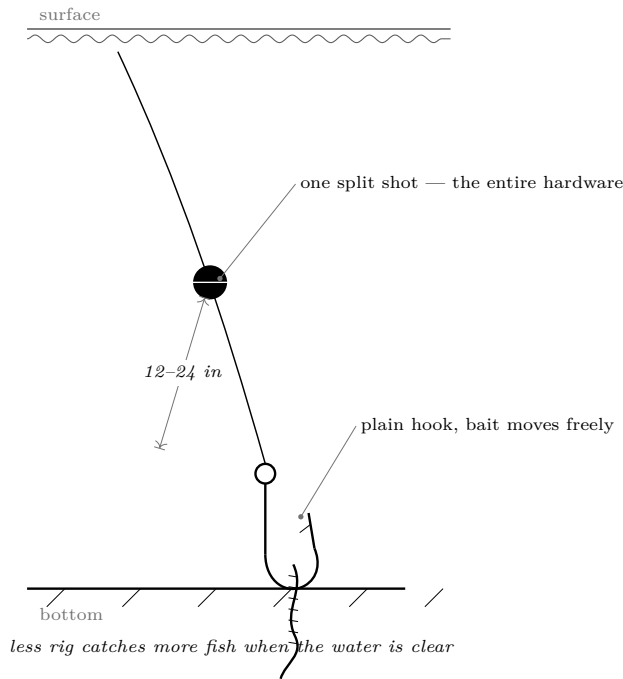
When to use it

Any time you know the depth and want the bait to stay there: over a weed edge, over a crappie school suspended at 14 ft, over a bluegill bed, or with a big sucker over a weed flat for pike. It is the most controllable live-bait presentation there is, and it is the easiest rig in this guide to hand to a beginner.

Split Shot Rig

A hook, a pinch of lead, and nothing else

The least rig you can get away with — and often the best



What it does	One small weight pinched on the line 12–24 in above a plain hook. It gives just enough weight to cast and to sink, and leaves the bait free to move naturally.
Why it matters	Every other rig on these sheets adds hardware, and hardware adds unnatural motion. When fish are wary, less rig catches more fish.
Components	A hook. A split shot. That is all.
Shot size	BB or size 5 for panfish; size 3 or larger, or two shot, for bass and smallmouth in deeper water.
Removable shot	Buy the kind with wings on the back so you can reopen and reposition them. You will move the shot constantly.
Catches	Everything. Rock bass, perch, bluegill, smallmouth on a live crayfish, walleye on a leech.

Fish it

1. Pinch one shot on the line, using pliers or your teeth — but never on fluorocarbon leader you care about, because crimping weakens it at that point.
2. Cast out and let it sink on a semi-tight line, watching where the line enters the water.
3. Retrieve in slow, small pulls with long pauses, or simply let it sit on the bottom and wait.
4. Move the shot to change how the bait behaves: closer to the hook makes it sink faster and act tighter, further away lets it drift and swim more freely.

Where it beats a better rig

Wary fish	Pine Lake in flat calm. A single small shot is less unnatural than a jig head or a bullet weight.
Live crayfish	Hook one through the tail with a plain hook and one shot, and drift it across gravel at Pine spots 2, 3 or 4 . Very few smallmouth refuse it.
Teaching	Two components and no rigging. A child can build it in twenty seconds and understand what every part does.
Repair	When you snap off the fancy rig in a rock pile and the light is going, this is the rig you can retie in the dark.
Not for	Heavy weed — the exposed hook fouls. Use a <i>see the Texas rig sheet</i> there instead.

When to use it

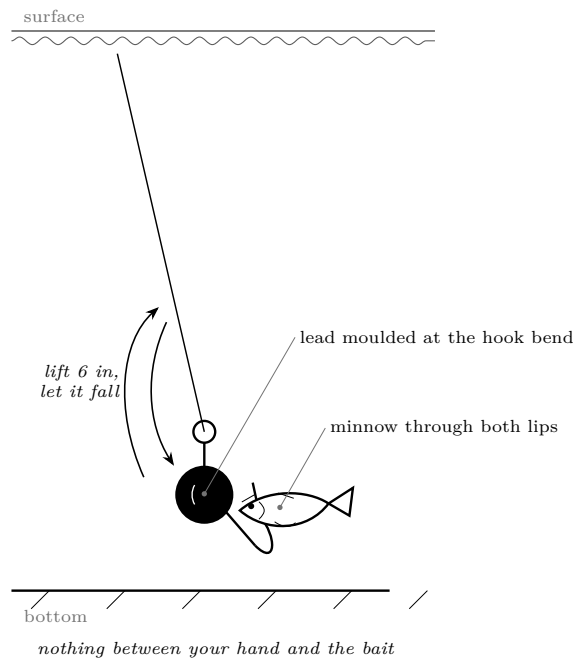
Whenever you catch yourself adding hardware to solve a problem that is actually caused by hardware. Start every unfamiliar spot with a split shot and a piece of live bait: it tells you what lives there before you commit to a technique.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Split Shot Rig. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Jig and Minnow

One hook, one weight, one piece of bait

The simplest way to put a bait exactly where a walleye is



What it does	Weight and hook in one piece, so you feel everything and control the depth absolutely. There is nothing between your hand and the bait.
Why it matters	In cold water a walleye's take is a barely perceptible change in weight. A jig transmits that; almost nothing else does.
Weight	1/8 oz to 15 ft, 1/4 oz to 25 ft, 3/8 oz deeper or in wind. Use the lightest head that still lets you feel bottom.
Head shape	Round for vertical work; a stand-up head for dragging on a clean bottom.
Bait	A 2-3 in fathead or shiner hooked up through both lips. A half crawler or a leech works in warmer water.
Line	6-8 lb. Braid with a fluorocarbon leader if you want maximum feel in deep water.

Fish it

1. Lower or cast, and let it fall on a **semi-tight** line. Watch and feel — a good share of bites happen on the initial drop, and on a fully slack line you will never know.
2. When it hits bottom, lift the rod tip about six inches and **let it fall back under control**, following it down with the rod. The fall is the presentation. The lift only sets up the next fall.
3. Pause on the bottom for a two-count. Repeat.
4. If you are casting, work the jig back with the same lift-and-fall while the boat holds on the contour.

Reading the bite

The classic take	You lift and the jig feels <i>heavy</i> — as though you picked up a wet leaf. That is a walleye. Sweep the rod immediately.
The tick	A single sharp tap on the fall. Set at once.
Nothing	Sometimes the jig simply stops falling early. Set.
Do not snap	A firm upward sweep sets a single sharp hook. A violent snap tears it out of a soft mouth.
Stay vertical	Keep the line as close to straight up and down as the drift allows. Line at an angle costs you feel and costs you hooksets.
Where	Pine spots 2, 3, 4 and 8 ; North spots 2, 3 and 4 . 15-35 ft.

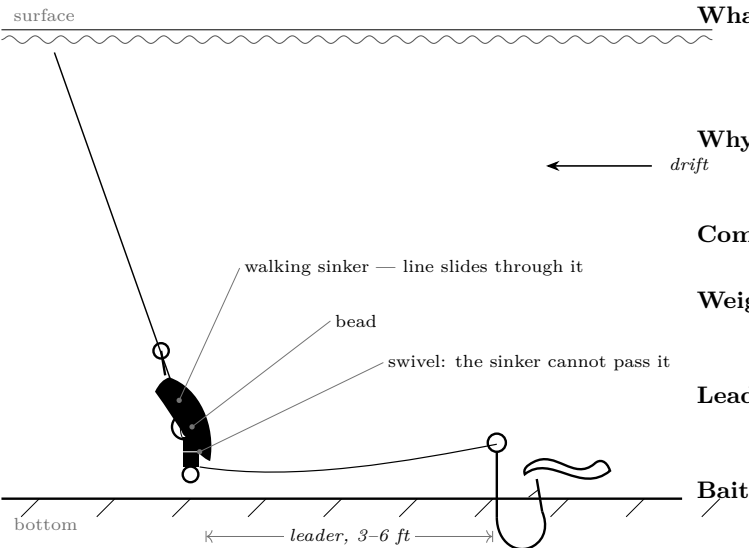
When to use it
Cold water — ice-out through May, and again from October on — and any time you can see fish on electronics and want to put something on their heads. It is also the best rig for teaching feel, because everything that happens to the jig arrives in your hand.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Jig and Minnow. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Lindy Rig

Drag live bait along the bottom and let the fish take line

The walleye rig — also called a slip-sinker or live-bait rig



What it does	The sinker drags the bottom; the line slides <i>through</i> it. When a fish picks up the bait it feels no weight at all, so it keeps moving instead of dropping the bait.
Why it matters	A cold-water walleye mouths a bait and spits anything that resists. This rig removes the resistance.
Components	Walking or egg sinker, bead, barrel swivel, 3–6 ft leader, single hook.
Weight	1/4 oz to 20 ft, 3/8 oz to 30 ft, 1/2 oz deeper or in wind. Use the lightest that keeps bottom contact.
Leader	Long and light in Pine Lake’s clear water — 6 ft of 6 lb fluorocarbon. Shorter and heavier on North Lake.
Bait	Leech, half a nightcrawler, or a lively minnow hooked through the lips.

Build it

1. Thread the **sinker** onto the main line, narrow end first, so the line runs freely through it.
2. Add a **bead** to protect the knot from the sinker.
3. Tie the main line to one eye of a **barrel swivel**. The swivel is the stop: the sinker rides above it and cannot reach the hook.
4. Tie the **leader** to the other eye, then the **hook** to the leader.

Fish it

Speed	Slower than feels right. Drift with the wind or use the electric motor at a crawl — roughly the speed you would walk a dog that keeps stopping.
Contact	You must feel the sinker ticking bottom. If you cannot, add weight; if it is plowing, take weight off.
The take	You will feel weight, or a tap, or simply nothing where there was bottom a moment ago. Do not set the hook.
Feed it	Open the bail or drop the rod tip and give the fish line for a slow count of five to ten. The fish is turning the bait to swallow it head first.
Then set	Close the bail, reel until the line comes tight, and sweep the rod. No snap.
Follow the contour	Keep the boat on one depth line. A walleye break is a line, not a spot.

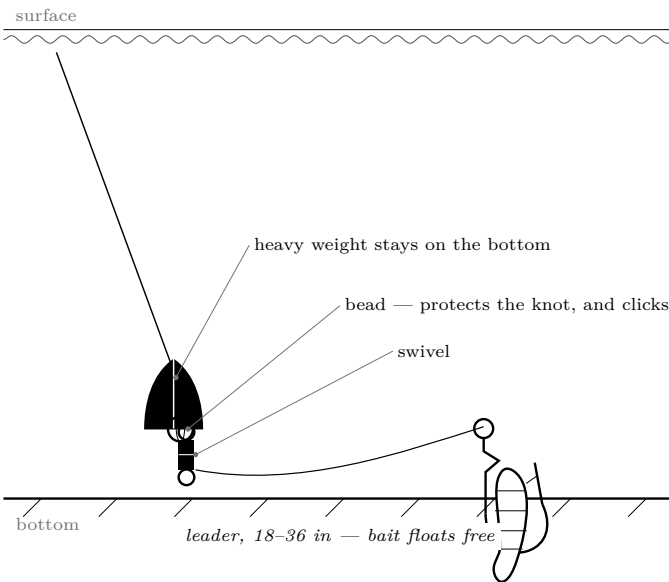
When to use it
Pine Lake spots 3 and 8 , North Lake spot 3 , in 18–35 ft. It is the highest-percentage way to catch a walleye on either lake, and it doubles as a smallmouth and perch rig. It is also the rig that most rewards patience: the whole thing depends on giving line to a fish that has not yet decided to keep your bait.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Lindy Rig. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Carolina Rig

The bottom-searching bass rig

Cover a lot of bottom and keep the bait floating just above it



What it does

A heavy weight stays on the bottom and telegraphs exactly what the bottom is made of, while the bait trails behind on a long leader, floating free.

Versus Texas

A Texas rig puts the weight *at* the bait; a Carolina rig separates them. Texas gets into cover; Carolina covers ground and keeps the bait visible.

Components

3/8–3/4 oz weight, glass or brass bead, barrel swivel, 18–36 in leader, offset hook, soft plastic.

The bead

Sits between weight and swivel. It protects the knot and it clicks — an audible attractor on a hard bottom.

Leader length

Short (18 in) in cold water or heavy weed; long (36 in) in clear water and on a clean bottom.

Line

15 lb main, 10–12 lb leader, so a snag breaks off the bait and not the whole rig.

Build it

1. Thread the **weight** onto the main line, then the **bead**.
2. Tie the main line to a **barrel swivel**.
3. Tie the **leader** to the other end of the swivel, then the **hook** to the leader.
4. Rig the plastic weedless exactly as for a *see the **Texas rig** sheet*, or on an open hook if the bottom is clean.

Fish it

Cast long	This is a long-cast rig. The weight carries it, and the long leader means it needs a slow, wide casting stroke or it will tangle.
Drag, do not hop	Sweep the rod sideways, low and slow, to drag the weight across the bottom. Reel up the slack, reposition, sweep again.
Feel the bottom	You are mapping structure by touch. Sand feels smooth, gravel grinds, rock knocks, weeds load and release. Slow down when the bottom changes — that is where fish are.
The bite	Usually a distinct tick or a mushy weight. Reel down until tight, then sweep. Do not snap.
Where	Pine spot 5 on the outside weed edge, and the flats around the base of the bar at 4 . North spots 3 and 4 .

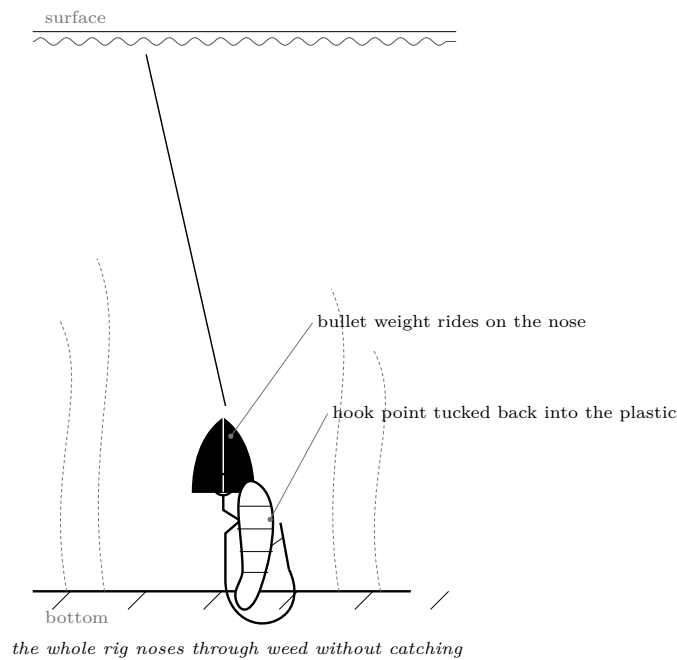
When to use it
When you need to find fish on a big, featureless-looking flat. The Carolina rig is a search tool that happens to catch fish: it tells you where the bottom changes, and bass live where the bottom changes.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Carolina Rig. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See **LICENSE** and **CREDITS.md** in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Texas Rig

The weedless bass rig

Put a soft plastic inside heavy cover without hanging up



What it does	A cone-shaped weight slides down to the nose of a soft plastic, and the hook point is tucked back inside the plastic body. The whole thing noses through weed, wood and rock without catching.
Why it matters	Largemouth live inside cover. Any rig that hangs up in cover cannot reach them.
Components	Bullet weight, optional peg or bobber stop, offset worm hook, soft plastic.
Weight	1/8 oz over sparse weed, 1/4–3/8 oz to punch through thick stuff. Lighter falls slower and gets more bites.
Hook	3/0–4/0 offset worm hook for a 6 in worm; 4/0–5/0 for a creature bait.
Line	12–15 lb. You are pulling fish out of salad; this is not the place for 6 lb.

Rig the plastic — this is the whole trick

1. Slide the **bullet weight** on, point first, then tie on the hook. Peg the weight with a bobber stop if you want it to stay at the nose in heavy cover; leave it free to slide if you want the bait to fall away from the weight.
2. Push the hook point into the exact centre of the worm’s nose and out the side after about **1/4 inch**. Not more.
3. Slide the worm up over the hook eye and onto the line.
4. Rotate the hook 180 degrees so the point faces the worm’s body.
5. Lay the hook alongside the worm to see where the point lands, then push it through at that spot and back out — then **pull it back** until the point just sits under the plastic skin. The worm must hang perfectly straight. A worm with a kink in it spins and fish will not eat it.

Fish it

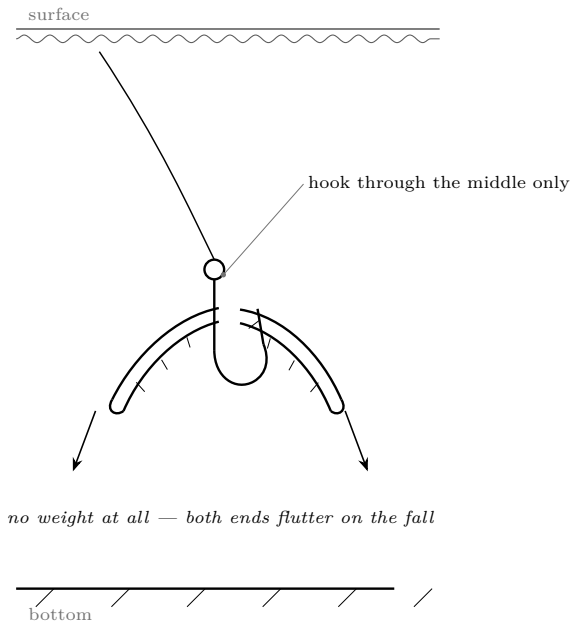
Cast and watch	Most bites come on the initial fall. Watch your line where it enters the water — if it jumps, twitches, or stops falling early, set the hook.
Work it	Lift the rod tip slowly to drag the bait a foot, then let it fall back on a controlled slack line. Repeat. You are feeling for weight, not waiting for a tug.
Set hard	Unlike every other rig on this sheet, this one needs a hard, fast, upward set — you have to drive the point out through the plastic and into bone.
Where	Pine spots 5 and 6 , North spots 1 and 7 . Into the weeds, not along them.

When to use it
When the fish are <i>in</i> cover rather than beside it: matted weed, laydowns, dock pilings, the inside edge of a weed bed on a hot afternoon. If you can fish an open weed edge, a <i>see the Carolina rig sheet</i> covers water faster — but nothing else gets into the thick stuff and comes back out.

Wacky Rig

The clear-water finesse rig

One hook, one worm, no weight — and it out-fishes everything in clear water



What it does	A straight soft-plastic worm hooked through its middle, with no weight at all. On the fall both halves shimmy independently. Nothing else in fishing moves like it.
Why it works	It falls slowly, horizontally, and looks alive while doing nothing. In water as clear as Pine Lake's, a slow horizontal fall beats an active retrieve.
Components	One 1/0 or 2/0 octopus or wide-gap hook, one 5 in stick worm. That is the entire rig.
O-ring	Slide a small rubber O-ring onto the worm's middle and hook under the ring instead of through the plastic. One worm then lasts twenty fish instead of two.
Line	6–10 lb. Spinning tackle. Fluorocarbon leader on Pine Lake.
Catches	Largemouth above all; smallmouth and big bluegill will take it too.

Fish it

1. Cast past the target — a dock, a weed clump, an edge — and **do nothing**.
2. Watch the line. The worm is falling on a slack line and almost every bite happens here. If the line twitches, jumps, or stops falling, reel down and sweep.
3. If it reaches the bottom untouched, give the rod two small shakes, then let it sit for a slow count of five.
4. Lift, let it fall again, and repeat. Retrieve slowly and cast again.

Getting it right

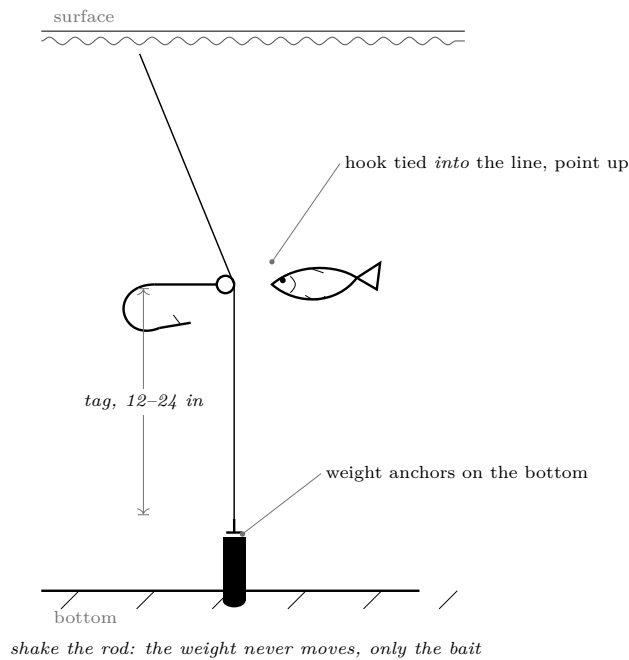
Patience	The single most common mistake is fishing it too fast. This rig catches fish while it is doing nothing. If you feel like you are wasting time, you are probably fishing it correctly.
Watch the line	You will not feel most bites. You will see them. Keep a slight bow in the line and keep your eyes on where it enters the water.
Wind	The one condition it hates. In a chop you cannot see the line; switch to a <i>see the Texas rig sheet</i> or a jig.
Where	Pine spots 5 , 6 and 7 — especially in bright, calm, high-sun conditions when nothing else produces. North spots 1 and 7 .
Hookset	A firm sweep, not a snap. The hook is exposed; it does not need to be driven through plastic.

When to use it
Bright sun, flat calm, clear water, pressured fish — exactly the conditions where everyone else stops catching. On Pine Lake in July this is the highest-percentage bass presentation on the sheet, and it takes ten seconds to tie.

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Drop Shot

Weight on the bottom, bait suspended above it, both under your control



What it does	Everything else puts the weight above the bait. This puts it below. The weight anchors on the bottom and the bait hovers a fixed distance above it, where you can shake it in place indefinitely without moving it.
Why it matters	Fish that will not chase will still eat something that hangs in front of them. This is the rig for a tough day in deep clear water.
Components	Cylinder or teardrop weight, size 1 or 1/0 drop-shot hook, small minnow-shaped plastic.
Tag length	12 in for bottom-hugging perch and smallmouth; 24-36 in for fish suspended off a drop.
Line	6-8 lb fluorocarbon on spinning tackle.
Catches	Smallmouth, walleye, perch, crappie, largemouth. On Pine Lake's east wall it is the most reliable summer rig there is.

Build it

1. Tie a **Palomar knot** with the hook, but leave a very long tag end — 2 to 3 ft.
2. Pass that tag end **back down through the hook eye**, from the top. This is the step everyone forgets, and it is what makes the hook stand out from the line at right angles with the point up.
3. Attach the **weight** to the bottom of the tag with a simple overhand loop, or crimp it into the weight's line clip so it pulls free on a snag instead of costing you the rig.
4. Nose-hook the plastic through the very tip so it hangs horizontally and free.

Fish it

Drop straight down	This is primarily a vertical rig. Get over the fish and lower it.
Feel the weight land	Once it is down, take up slack until the line is just tight to the weight, and then stop reeling.
Shake, do not lift	Shake the rod tip. The weight never moves; only the bait quivers. That is the entire presentation, and you can do it in one spot for a minute at a time.
The bite	Often just added weight, or the line moving sideways. Reel down and sweep — no snap, small hook.
Where	Pine spots 3 (the east wall) and 4 (down the sides of the bar), 25-40 ft. North spots 3 and 4 .

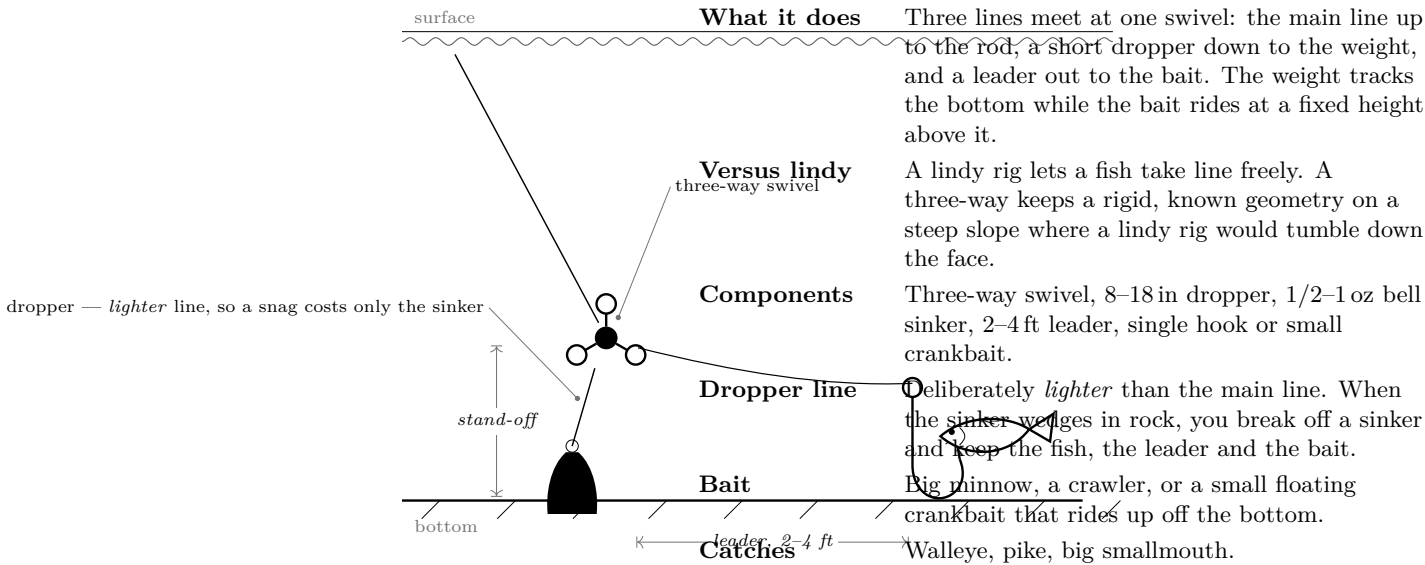
When to use it
August on Pine Lake, when the fish are deep, the sun is high and nothing is chasing. It is also the best rig in the guide for fishing a spot you can see on electronics: put it on their nose and leave it there.

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Three-Way Rig

Also called a wolf river rig

Hold a precise depth on a steep face where nothing else will



Build it

1. Tie the **main line** to the top eye of the three-way swivel.
2. Tie a short **dropper** of lighter line to the bottom eye, and the **sinker** to its end. Make the dropper as long as you want the bait to ride above the bottom.
3. Tie the **leader** to the third eye, then the hook or lure to the leader.

Fish it

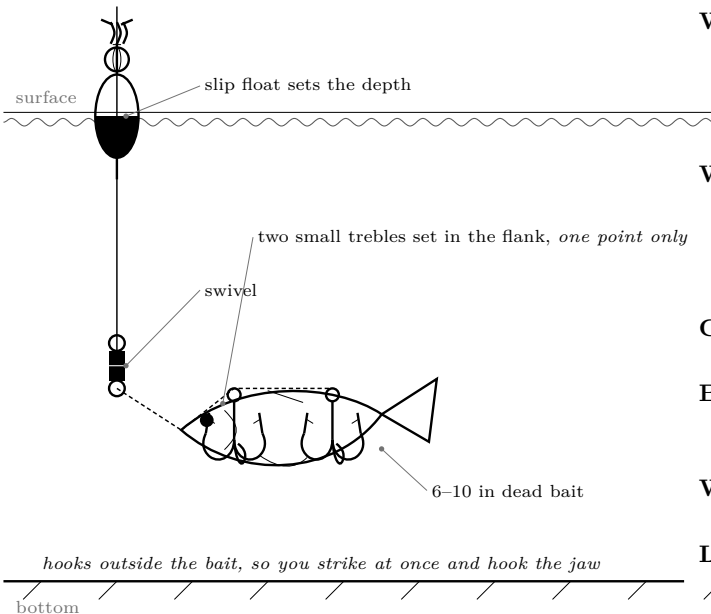
Troll or drift slowly	Move at a walking pace with the sinker just ticking bottom. The rig is designed to be moving.
Vertical line	Keep the line close to straight down. Let line out until you touch bottom, then take up a few inches. Re-check constantly on a slope — that is the whole point of the rig.
Feel for the change	You are following a contour. When the sinker stops touching, you have moved deep; when it drags hard, you have moved shallow. Steer to keep contact.
Set	A steady sweep. The fish usually hooks itself against the moving boat.
Where	Pine spot 3 — the east wall is the exact situation this rig was invented for — and the steep side of the bar at 4 . North spot 3 .

When to use it
On a drop too steep to fish any other way. If you keep losing bottom contact and then plowing, alternately, on a sharp break, this is the rig. It also lets you fish a floating crankbait a fixed 18 inches off the rocks, which is deadly on fall walleye.

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Quick-Strike Rig

Fish a big dead bait for pike and hook the fish, not its stomach



What it does	Two small treble hooks set into the flank of a large dead bait, on a wire trace. Because the hooks are on the <i>outside</i> of the bait, you strike immediately instead of waiting for the pike to swallow.
Why it matters	The old method — a single hook inside a bait, and a long wait — gut-hooks pike and kills fish you meant to release. A quick-strike rig hooks them in the jaw. This is the humane way to do it, and it is also more effective.
Components	Wire trace with two size 6–8 trebles, barrel swivel, slip float and stop, large dead bait.
Bait	A dead sucker, smelt or large shiner, 6–10 in. Dead bait works: pike scavenge readily, especially in cold water.
Wire	Not optional. Pike teeth cut monofilament instantly.
Line	20 lb braid or 15 lb mono; a rod with backbone.

Build and bait it

1. Rig the **slip float** on the main line — stop knot, bead, float — exactly as on the *see the slip bobber sheet* sheet. Set the depth so the bait hangs just above the weed tops.
2. Tie the main line to a **barrel swivel**, and the swivel to the **wire trace**.
3. Set the **rear treble** into the bait's flank near the tail, one point only, barely under the skin.
4. Set the **front treble** near the head, again one point only. The bait should hang naturally, not bent.

Fish it

Strike early	When the float goes down, count to five , reel until tight, and sweep hard. Do not give it a minute. Do not give it thirty seconds. The whole design assumes an early strike.
Tackle at hand	Long-nose pliers, side cutters and jaw spreaders in the boat before you cast, not after you hook one.
Cut, do not dig	If a hook is awkward, cut the treble with side cutters and back the pieces out. A cheap hook is worth less than the fish.
Where	Pine spots 1 and 9 in April and again in October; the deep weed edge at 5 in summer. North spots 2 , 5 and 6 .
Ice	The same rig on a tip-up is the standard big-pike presentation, <i>see the tip-up sheet</i> .

HANDLE PIKE PROPERLY

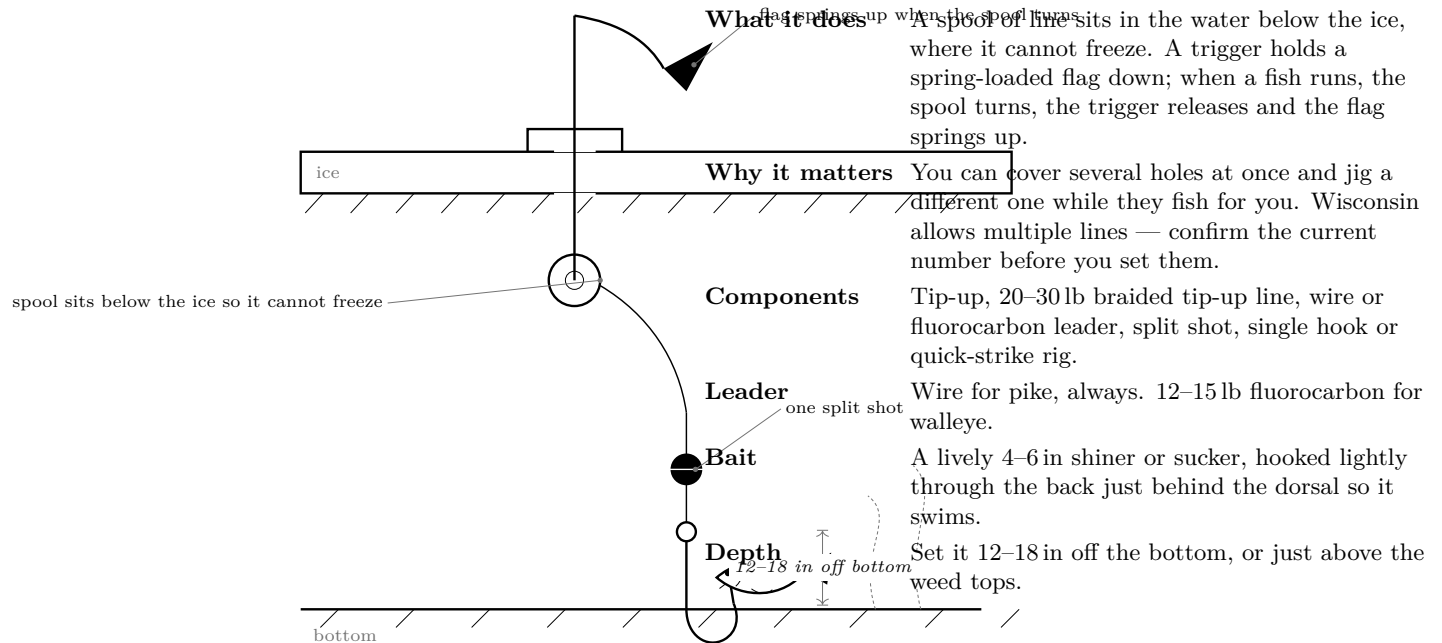
Backward-facing teeth, and a fish strong enough to thrash while you work. Jaw spreaders and long pliers every time; fingers never inside the mouth or under the gill plate. Pike over 70 °F water are fragile — unhook in the net, in the water, and release quickly. See the **Northern Pike** sheet.

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Tip-Up

Winter pike and walleye

Fish live bait under the ice while you fish somewhere else



Set it

1. Drill the hole and clear the slush completely, or the flag will freeze down and never trip.
2. Drop the baited rig until it touches bottom, then reel up 12-18 in and mark that line depth with a rubber band or a clip so you can reset the same depth all day.
3. Set the trigger with the flag bent under it. Test it once by hand — a trigger set too tight will not release for a fish.
4. Bank snow around the base of the tip-up to keep the hole from refreezing.

When the flag goes

Walk, do not run	Footsteps on clear ice carry. Approach quietly, especially in shallow water.
Watch the spool	If it is still turning, the fish is moving. Let it run. If it has stopped, wait until it starts again — that is the fish turning the bait.
Set by hand	Pick the line up off the spool, take up slack until you feel the fish, and pull firmly hand over hand. There is no rod to absorb a snap, so a smooth strong pull is correct.
Bring it up hand over hand	Lay line on the ice away from the hole so it cannot tangle back down.
Where	Pine spots 1 , 6 and 9 over weed edges in 8-15 ft; North spots 1 and 5 . Pike season closes 7 March — check the current dates.

ICE IS NEVER GUARANTEED

No ice is safe ice. Check thickness yourself as you go rather than trusting somebody else's report; four inches of clear ice is a common minimum for one person on foot, and more for a group. Springs, inlets, outlets and current thin the ice unpredictably — on North Lake the river inflow and outflow at spots **2** and **6** are exactly the places to stay off. Carry ice picks around your neck, take a rope, and do not go out alone.

IV Reference

Why fish are where they are, what to carry, when to go, the four knots that cover everything here, how to put a fish back so it lives, and how to take somebody out for the first time.

Reading Water

*The sheet that makes the other sheets
portable*

Why fish are where they are, so you can find them on any lake

Every numbered spot in this guide was chosen by the same reasoning, and once you can do that reasoning yourself you no longer need the numbers. Fish are not distributed evenly. They stack up wherever two things meet.

The one idea: fish live on edges

What an edge is	Any place where the water changes — shallow to deep, weed to open, hard bottom to soft, warm to cold, bright to shaded, current to still. An edge gives a predator cover on one side and hunting ground on the other, and it concentrates the food chain from the bottom up.
The best spots have two	A weed edge is good. A weed edge on a point is better. A weed edge on a point next to a fast drop into deep water is where everything in the lake eventually shows up. Pine Lake's mid-lake bar is four edges stacked in one place, which is why it is spot 4.
The featureless middle	A flat, uniform bottom in open water holds almost nothing. If you cannot name the edge you are fishing, you are probably not fishing anything.

The edges worth finding, in order

Edge	Why fish use it	On these lakes
Break (drop-off)	A fish can move between shallow feeding and deep safety without crossing open water. The steeper the break, the less distance that move costs, so steep breaks hold fish through more of the day.	Pine 3 (east wall), 8; North 3, 7
Weed edge	The outside line where weed growth stops for lack of light. Bait hides inside it, predators patrol outside it. In clear water it is deep; in stained water it is shallow.	Pine 5 at 12–18 ft; North 1 at 6–10 ft
Point	A finger of shallow ground reaching into deep water. It intercepts fish moving along a shoreline and it catches wind. Fish the <i>end</i> , not the sides.	Pine 2, 8; North 3
Bar or hump	Shallow structure isolated in deep water. The best of all, because it is the only cover for a long way and fish have to commit to it.	Pine 4; North 4
Inside turn	A notch where the depth line bends back toward shore. Fish moving along a break funnel into it.	Pine 2, 7; North 2
Neck or narrows	Anywhere a lake pinches. Everything that moves between two areas passes through, and current keeps the bottom clean.	North 5
Inlet / outlet	Moving water: different temperature, oxygen, and a constant delivery of food. First place to look in early spring and late fall.	Pine 9; North 2, 6
Wind-blown shore	Wind pushes plankton against a bank, then baitfish, then predators. Uncomfortable to fish, which is exactly why it is uncrowded.	Whichever side the wind is on
Shade line	The edge of a dock, an overhanging tree, a weed mat. A fish in shade sees out; you cannot see in. Midday, high sun.	Pine 6, 7; North 1

The invisible edge: the thermocline

What happens	By early summer a deep lake settles into three layers: a warm mixed layer on top, a thin band where temperature falls sharply — the thermocline — and cold, dense water below.
Why it matters	The layers stop mixing. Below the thermocline, oxygen is no longer being replenished. In most lakes that makes the deep water uninhabitable by midsummer, so <i>every fish in the lake</i> is squeezed into the water above it.
Pine Lake is the exception	It is deep and clean enough to keep oxygen in the cold layer, which is why it holds cisco. That means predators here have somewhere to go that most lakes do not — and in July and August they go there. <i>see the Cisco sheet</i>
How to find it	On sonar it is often a faint horizontal band of clutter. Or lower a thermometer: where the reading drops several degrees in a couple of feet, that is it. Typically 15–25 ft in this part of Wisconsin.
Turnover	In autumn the surface cools until the layers have the same density and the whole lake mixes. For a week or two the water looks cloudy and the fishing is genuinely poor. Then it is the best month of the year.

A method for a lake you have never seen

1. Look at a contour map *before* you launch and mark every point, bar, inside turn and narrows. That is your list of candidate spots and it costs nothing.
2. On the water, find the weed line first. It tells you how far light penetrates, which tells you how deep everything else will be.
3. Start shallow and early. Work out and down as the sun climbs.
4. Fish an edge, not an area. Keep the boat on one depth and follow it.
5. When you catch one, stop and note the depth, the bottom, and the edge. Then find the same combination somewhere else on the lake — fish are creatures of pattern, and the pattern repeats.

The point of the numbered spots

The nine spots on Pine Lake and the seven on North Lake are not secrets; they are worked examples. Each one is a named edge, and the lake sheets say which edge and why. Learn the reasoning and you can walk up to any lake in the county and produce your own list before you get the boat wet.

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Lures & Baits

Pine Lake & North Lake

What to carry, and what each thing is actually for

A tackle box fills up with things that catch fishermen. This sheet is the short list that catches fish on these two lakes, with the reason each item exists. Buy depth and colour variety in the few categories that matter, not one of everything.

Hard baits

Lure	Size	What it is for and how to work it	Target
Inline spinner	1/8–1/4 oz	Steady retrieve, blade turning. The simplest lure that works. Excellent for a beginner because a constant speed is all it needs.	Panfish, bass, pike
Spinnerbait	3/8–3/4 oz	Safety-pin wire arm makes it near-weedless. Slow-roll it over and through weed tops. The pike lure on North Lake.	Pike, largemouth
Squarebill crankbait	2–2.5 in	Dives 3–6 ft and deflects off cover. Bump it into weeds and rock; the strike comes as it ricochets.	Largemouth, smallmouth
Deep crankbait	2.5–3 in	Dives 12–20 ft. Trolled or cast along a break. Fall walleye.	Walleye, pike
Suspending jerkbait	4–5 in	Twitch, twitch, <i>pause</i> . The pause is the presentation — count to five in cold water.	Smallmouth, walleye, pike
Casting spoon	1/2–1 oz	Flutters on the fall. Cast, count down, retrieve in sweeps. Also the standard ice jigging spoon.	Pike, walleye
Walking topwater	4 in	Rod-tip cadence makes it swing side to side. First and last light only.	Largemouth
Popper	2–3 in	Chug, pause, chug. Over shallow weed on calm summer mornings.	Largemouth, big bluegill

Soft plastics and jigs

Item	Size	What it is for	Rig it on
Stick worm	5 in	The single most productive bass bait on Pine Lake. Buy these before anything else.	see the <i>wacky rig</i> sheet, see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet
Ribbon-tail worm	7 in	More action on the fall than a stick worm; better in stained water.	see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet, see the <i>Carolina rig</i> sheet
Tube	3–4 in	Spirals and puffs like a fleeing crayfish. The best smallmouth bait there is.	Tube jig head
Craw / creature	3–4 in	Bulk and appendages. Punching weed and flipping wood.	see the <i>Texas rig</i> sheet
Minnow-shaped plastic	3–4 in	Slim profile that hangs horizontally.	see the <i>drop-shot</i> sheet
Round jig head	1/16–3/8 oz	Weight and hook in one. Carry the whole range — depth dictates weight.	see the <i>jig-and-minnow</i> sheet
Panfish jig	1/32–1/16 oz	Tiny hair or plastic jig under a float or on its own.	see the <i>slip bobber</i> sheet
Bass jig & trailer	3/8–1/2 oz	Weedguard and a skirt. Slow, deliberate, big-fish bait around wood and weed edges.	Direct tie

Live bait

Bait	When and why	Hook it
Nightcrawler	The universal bait. Half a crawler out-fishes a whole one for panfish, because a small mouth cannot get the whole thing.	Thread on, leave a short tail moving
Leech	The best walleye bait from late May through summer. Swims with a ribbon motion nothing imitates.	Once through the sucker end
Fathead minnow	Cold water: ice-out through May, and October on. Hardy in the bucket.	Up through both lips
Golden shiner	Bigger, flashier, more fragile. Pike and walleye.	Through the back, behind the dorsal
Sucker (dead, 6–10 in)	Winter and cold-water pike. Dead bait works — pike scavenge.	see the <i>quick-strike rig sheet</i>
Waxworm / spike	Ice fishing and tight-lipped summer panfish.	One or two on a tiny jig
Crayfish	The premium smallmouth bait on Pine Lake’s gravel.	Plain hook through the tail, one split shot

Colour, in one paragraph

Pine Lake is very clear: natural and translucent colours — green pumpkin, watermelon, smoke, silver, real crayfish brown. North Lake is stained: brighter and more solid — chartreuse, white, black, gold, firetiger. In both lakes, black or dark purple is the most visible silhouette in low light and at night. If you only ever carry three soft-plastic colours, carry green pumpkin, black, and white.

Do not move live bait between waters. Wisconsin has strict rules on transporting live fish and water to prevent spreading invasive species and disease. Drain everything, and dispose of unused bait in the trash rather than the lake. Confirm the current bait rules with the DNR — they are enforced.

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Seasonal Calendar

*Pine Lake & North Lake — the whole year
on one sheet*

Which fish, which month, which depth, which spot

Fish do not follow the calendar; they follow water temperature, and the calendar is only a rough proxy for it. A cold spring pushes everything two weeks late. Use the temperature column, not the month, whenever you can measure it.

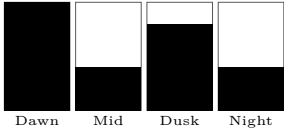
The year by species

Species	Activity by month	Peak periods and where
Largemouth bass	Activity levels: Jan (low), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (medium), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (medium-high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (low).	May–Jun shallow, pre-spawn and spawn: Pine 6, 7; North 1, 7. Sep–Oct feeding hard on the weed edge: Pine 5; North 1.
Smallmouth bass	Activity levels: Jan (low), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (medium), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (low).	May–Jun on gravel: Pine 2, 4. Oct the best of the year: Pine 3, 4; North 4.
Walleye	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (medium).	Oct–Nov on the breaks: Pine 3, 4, 8; North 3, 4. Dawn and dusk all year.
Northern pike	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (high), Apr (high), May (medium-high), Jun (medium-high), Jul (medium), Aug (medium), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (medium-high).	Apr post-spawn in the shallows and Oct–Nov feeding up: Pine 1, 9; North 2, 6.
Bluegill	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (medium-high).	Late May–Jun on the beds: Pine 6; North 1. Deep weed edge after.
Pumpkinseed	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (medium-high).	Same beds as bluegill, slightly shallower and tighter to cover.
Black crappie	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (medium-high), Jul (medium), Aug (medium), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (high).	May near brush and Jan through the ice. Dusk always.
Yellow perch	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (high), Apr (high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (high), Aug (high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (high).	Dec–Feb the best perch fishing of the year, on the 15–30 ft flats. Daylight only.
Rock bass	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (high), Aug (high), Sep (high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (medium-high).	Jun–Aug on any rock. The reliable summer fish for a child.
Cisco	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (low), May (low), Jun (low), Jul (low), Aug (low), Sep (low), Oct (medium), Nov (high), Dec (high).	Nov–Dec spawning shallow; through the ice in Jan . Pine Lake only.

The year by water temperature

Water	Roughly	What is happening, and what to do
32–40 °F	Dec–Mar	Ice. Panfish in the bays, perch on the flats, pike on tip-ups over weed edges. Everything moves slowly; small baits, long pauses.
40–45 °F	Late Mar–Apr	Ice-out. Pike spawn in flooded shallows — the first fish to go. Walleye follow onto rock. Fish the north and west shorelines, which warm first.
45–55 °F	Apr–early May	Walleye spawn and then feed. Crappie push into bays. Slow presentations, live bait, dark bottoms that hold heat.
55–65 °F	May–early Jun	Bass spawn , largemouth first and smallmouth just after. Bass season opens the first Saturday in May. The single best window of the year for numbers of fish, shallow.
65–72 °F	Jun	Panfish spawn on colonial beds. Everything is shallow and visible. This is the month to take children.
72–80 °F	Jul–Aug	The lake stratifies. Fish split: some hold the deep weed edge, some go to the hard structure, and on Pine some suspend over the basin following cisco. Fish early, late, and deep.
72–60 °F	Sep	Turnover. The surface cools, the layers mix, and for one to two weeks the fishing is genuinely poor and the water may look cloudy. Wait it out.
60–45 °F	Oct–Nov	The best fishing of the year. Big fish feed heavily and move onto structure. Larger baits, and do not be afraid to fish the middle of the day.
45–33 °F	Nov–Dec	Deep and slow. Then first ice, which is often excellent — and the most dangerous ice of the season.

Times of day

		
Dawn	The most reliable hour on both lakes for almost everything. Non-negotiable in July and August.	
Midday	Perch and rock bass feed; most predators do not. Bright calm midday is when finesse presentations earn their keep, <i>see the wacky rig sheet</i> and <i>see the drop-shot sheet</i> .	
Dusk	The best hour for walleye and crappie. Be on the spot before the light goes rather than arriving with it.	
Night	Walleye and big pike keep feeding; panfish shut down entirely.	
Weather	A falling barometer ahead of a front turns fish on hard. The day after a cold front passes is the worst day of any week — go deeper, slow down, and downsize.	
Wind	Wind on a point or a bar concentrates plankton, then baitfish, then predators. Fish the windy shore, not the comfortable one.	

Season dates change every year. On these waters in 2026–27, gamefish open 2 May and bass, walleye and pike close 7 March; musky is open water only through 31 December; panfish are open all year. Confirm with the Wisconsin DNR before every trip.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Seasonal Calendar. Revised 2026-07-25. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.

Knots

Learn these four and stop there

Four knots will cover everything in this guide

Every knot weakens the line it is tied in; a good knot simply weakens it less. Two habits matter more than which knot you choose: **wet it before you pull it tight**, because friction burns and permanently weakens monofilament, and **seat it slowly with steady pressure**, then look at it. A knot with a crossed wrap is a knot that will fail on the best fish of the day.

The four

Knot	Use it for	How to tie it
Improved clinch	Hook, swivel or lure to line. The everyday knot.	Pass the tag through the eye. Twist the tag around the standing line five to seven times. Pass the tag back through the small loop right at the eye, then <i>back through the large loop</i> you just created — that second pass is the “improved” part and it is what stops it slipping. Wet and pull the standing line slowly. Trim close.
Palomar	Braid to anything; the <i>see the drop-shot sheet</i> . Stronger than a clinch and harder to tie wrong.	Double about six inches of line and pass the doubled loop through the eye. Tie a loose overhand knot with the doubled line, leaving the hook hanging. Pass the loop completely <i>over</i> the hook. Wet, then pull both the standing line and the tag to seat it. Trim.
Uni (grinner)	Leader to hook; and tied twice, back to back, it joins two lines of different diameter.	Pass the tag through the eye and lay it back alongside the standing line to form a loop. Wrap the tag through that loop and around both strands five or six times. Wet and pull the tag to close the coils, then slide the whole knot down to the eye.
Double surgeon’s	Joining leader to main line quickly, including with cold hands.	Lay the two lines alongside each other, overlapping by six inches. Treating them as one, tie a simple overhand knot, then pass the same ends through a second time. Wet, and pull all four ends at once. Trim both tags.

Getting them right

Wet every knot	Saliva or water, every time, before the final pull. A dry-cinched mono knot can lose a third of its strength to friction heat and you will never see the damage.
Pull the right end	On a clinch and a Palomar, seat the knot by pulling the <i>standing line</i> steadily — not by yanking the tag.
Leave a short tag	About 1/8 inch. Cutting flush lets the tag pull back through under load; leaving half an inch collects weed.
Look at it	Coils should lie in a neat barrel with no crossovers. If it looks wrong it is wrong. Cut it off and tie it again — it takes twenty seconds.
Retie often	After every fish over a couple of pounds, after any snag, and after fishing rock. Run the last two feet of line between your fingers: if you feel roughness, cut it back and retie.
Braid is different	Braid is slippery. Use a Palomar, or add extra wraps to a uni. A standard clinch in braid will slip.

Two things that are not knots

Snap swivel	A fast way to change lures, and it lets a lure swing freely. But it is one more failure point and it is visible — so on Pine Lake’s clear water, tie direct.
Wire leader	Not optional for pike, <i>see the Northern Pike sheet</i> . Most are pre-made with a swivel and snap. If you tie your own, use a haywire twist rather than trying to knot single-strand wire.

Teaching these

Practise on rope or paracord first, at a size a child can see, before touching 6 lb monofilament on a windy dock. Learn the improved clinch until it can be tied without looking, then the Palomar. Those two alone will cover everything on every rig sheet in this guide.

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Handling & Release

Do this right and it costs you thirty seconds

A released fish that dies anyway was not released

Most fish you catch on these lakes go back — everything under 14 inches, every bass out of season, and anything you simply do not need. Whether those fish survive is decided almost entirely in the sixty seconds after they reach the boat, and almost all of it is under your control.

The rules, in order of how much they matter

- 1. Keep it in the water** Every second out of water is a second not breathing. Unhook a fish in the net, in the water, whenever you can. If you want a photograph, get the camera ready *first*, then lift.
- 2. Wet your hands** Dry hands, a dry towel and a dry deck strip the protective slime coat, and the raw patch underneath is where infection and fungus start. Wet hands, wet net, wet everything.
- 3. Support the weight** One hand under the belly on anything over a couple of pounds. Holding a heavy fish vertically by the jaw stretches and tears the joint and the organs behind it. A bass under about two pounds is fine held by the lower lip; above that, use two hands.
- 4. Never touch the gills** Gill filaments are exposed blood vessels. A fish bleeding from the gills is a fish that will die, whatever it looks like when it swims off. No fingers under the plate, ever.
- 5. Cut the line on a deep hook** If the hook is in the throat or gut, **do not dig for it**. Cut the line as close as you can and let the fish go. A left hook rusts out or is expelled; a torn oesophagus does not heal.
- 6. Revive it properly** Hold it upright, facing into any current, or move it gently *forward* through the water. Never sweep it back and forth — water runs the wrong way through the gills and it does harm rather than good. Let go when it kicks free on its own.

What makes it worse

Factor	What to do about it
Warm water	Above roughly 75 °F a fish recovers slowly and its oxygen demand is high. In July and August, keep handling times short, revive longer, and consider moving to a different lesson for the day if fish are clearly struggling. Pike are the most fragile of the lot in warm water.
Deep water	A fish pulled quickly from more than about 25–30 ft may suffer barotrauma: the swim bladder over-expands and it cannot swim down. Signs are bloating, bulging eyes, or a fish that floats on its side. If you are catching fish deep and intend to release them, fish shallower or keep what you catch.
Long fight	Playing a fish to complete exhaustion on light line is hard on it. Use tackle heavy enough to land the fish quickly.
Treble hooks	Three times the chance of a bad hookset. Crush the barbs, or replace a set of trebles with single hooks on baits you use around fish you will release.
Handling a pike	Backward-facing teeth and a fish strong enough to thrash. Jaw spreaders and long pliers, every time. <i>see the Northern Pike sheet</i>

Keep a fish properly, too

- | | |
|---------------------------------|--|
| Decide early | Kill it or release it in the first minute. A fish kept on a stringer for two hours and then released is worse off than one killed immediately, and it is worse eating than one iced immediately. |
| Ice it | A cooler with ice, not a bucket of lake water. Quality falls fast in a warm bucket, and this is the single biggest difference between panfish that taste good and panfish that do not. |
| Take a meal, not a limit | Especially on bluegill beds in June, where the big males you are catching are the ones guarding the nests. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i> |
| Know the rules | Length and bag limits are per water body and change every year. Measure before you decide. <i>see the Seasonal Calendar sheet</i> |

Clean, drain, dry. Before you leave a landing: remove all weed and mud, drain the livewell, bilge and bait bucket, and never move live fish or lake water to another water body. Wisconsin enforces this. Invasive species and fish disease move on trailers, and once they are in a lake like Pine they do not come back out.

Teaching it

This is the sheet to work through before the first trip, not after the first fish. A child who is taught to wet their hands and keep the fish in the net will do it for the rest of their life without thinking about it; one who learns it after dropping a bass on a hot dock has already learnt the other thing.

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A First Trip

Plan for catching, not for fishing

How to take somebody fishing who has never been

The failure mode of a first trip is always the same: an adult who wants to catch a good fish takes a beginner to a place where good fish live, and the beginner spends four hours not catching anything and concludes that fishing is boring. They are right. Plan the opposite trip.

The plan

Target bluegill	Not bass, not walleye, not "whatever bites". In June a bluegill bed will produce a fish every few minutes, and constant action is the entire point. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Go in June	Late May through June, when panfish are on the beds in 1–4 ft of water and you can see them. Pine Lake spot 6 ; North Lake spot 1 .
Go in the evening	Two hours before dark, not eight in the morning. Warmer, calmer, better bite, and a natural end to the trip.
Keep it short	Ninety minutes. Leave while it is still fun. The trip should end because you decided to end it, not because somebody has stopped enjoying it.
One rod each	A short spinning rod, 4lb line, a fixed bobber a couple of feet above a size 8 hook, half a worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i> — but use a fixed float, not a slip float, for the first trip.
Pinch the barbs	Flatten every barb with pliers. You will lose a few fish and you will save yourself the one memory that ends the hobby: a barbed hook in a finger, an hour from the car.

What to bring

- Rod, already rigged, at home
- A spare rod, also already rigged
- Worms, more than you think
- Long-nose pliers
- Nail clippers for line
- Landing net
- Wet towel
- Life jackets that fit *them*
- Sunscreen and a hat
- Bug spray
- Snacks and water — more than the fishing gear, honestly
- Something to keep fish in, if keeping
- A first-aid kit with tweezers

The first hour, in order

1. **Rig everything at home.** Not at the water, not in the wind, not while somebody is waiting. Arrive ready to cast.
2. **Life jackets on before the boat.** No discussion, and the adult wears one too — they will do what you do, not what you say.
3. **Five minutes on casting, on grass, before you leave.** A weight and no hook. Underhand flip, not overhead. It removes the largest source of frustration on the water.
4. **Anchor on the bed and stay put.** Do not run around looking for better. Better is worse.
5. **Let them do everything they can.** Bait the hook badly, cast badly, reel too fast. Your job is to untangle things and say very little.
6. **Show them the first fish properly.** Wet hands, look at the gill flap, name it, count the spines, let them hold it, put it back. *see the **Handling & Release sheet***
7. **Leave on a fish.** When the bite is still good and they are still laughing, that is the moment to go.

Things that go wrong, and the fix

Problem	Fix
Tangles	Inevitable. Carry the pre-rigged spare rod, hand it over, and untangle the first one later. Do not make a child stand and watch you pick at a bird's nest for ten minutes.
Nothing biting	You are in the wrong spot or too deep. Move shallower, go smaller, use less bait. Half a worm out-fishes a whole one for panfish every time.
Bored	The bite has slowed. Change activity rather than persisting: look at what is in the water, catch a crayfish under a rock, throw the cast net, go home. Fishing is not the only good thing about being at a lake.
Hook in a finger	This is why the barbs are pinched. Back it out the way it went in, clean it, plaster on it, carry on. With a barb still on, cut the line and see a doctor.
Frightened of the fish	Normal. Hold it yourself first, let them touch it while you hold it, and do not push. They will pick one up within a couple of trips.

The measure of success

Not the size of the fish, and not how many. The measure is whether they ask to go again. Everything on this sheet is arranged to make that answer yes.

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